

internalized, deeply rooted perspective that only daily decisions and mindset shifts can develop it. And what makes contentment especially difficult to discern is that it's not bad or shallow to want more and better. Contentment does not require you to suffer in silence, and there is no extra reward in retirement for martyrdom. When our stuff, situation, and status feel subpar, it can be easy to *still* think that more money and nicer things would solve the problem. But we want you to remember, you don't need more, different, or new to be happy.

You Don't Need More, Different, or New to Be Happy

So why is it so dang hard to be content? In a survey conducted by Empower Financial¹ with over two thousand Americans, it was discovered that people in every income bracket thought they needed to earn more money to be happy, with top income earners (those making \$250K+) believing they needed an additional \$150 to \$200K more per year in order to be happy. In contrast, most other brackets believed an increase of \$20K to \$50K annually would lead to greater happiness.

While there's a lot to dissect there, the thing that stands out to us the most is that no matter where we find ourselves, the propensity to imagine life being better with more will remain. And those with the most still don't think it's enough.

Unmet expectations, past experiences, the people around us, even certain seasons, can give us a distorted perception about what everyone else has and what we should have. Our distorted perception can often lead to jealousy and comparison. These play a strong role in the elusive nature of being satisfied, and they're hard to avoid when we see others around us taking fun vacations, driving newer cars, getting the sweet apartment, renovating their kitchen, or using top tier makeup and skin-care products. These are the times when it feels like our money is what's holding us back from the sweet life. We find ourselves thinking again that just a little more dough, that promotion, that job will give us the edge we need and then we will have enough. But those milestones happen, and our spending rises to meet our earning and we have a new metric for what will be our "enough."